

unexpected and unprecedented enjoyment of several triple-coupon sprees that filled Christmas baskets and my attic stairwell. Also that month, my mother died after a courageous battle with cancer. While cleaning out her closet, my sisters and a niece came across an unusually long, thin box. I gasped with amazed recognition when my niece opened it up and pulled out a delicate lavender umbrella with a swan head handle. It was an unopened premium from the Gloria Vanderbilt Company. For two empty flattened perfume boxes, they'd offered the lovely umbrella as a refund almost twenty years before. I'd had enough empty boxes in my files to have one sent to me and another to my mother. Here was definitive proof that she'd never even used it. I'll never know if she'd thought it too beautiful to use in the rain, or considered it worthless. Somehow it seemed appropriate that I discovered that past company premium while working on a book about coupons and refunding. Finding it abandoned in a closet made me wonder: Is "free" always a good deal? The free umbrella had done nothing for my mother, except take up valuable closet space.

If the TLC *Extreme Couponing* show and the discovery of the unused umbrella weren't enough to give me pause, I'd also began reading a book about hoarders and a description of their tendency to surround themselves with "stuff." This description of an avid "collector" is from that book, *Stuff: Compulsive Hoarding and the Meaning of Things* by Randy O. Frost & Gail Steketee:

*The fantasies increase the object's subjective value and give it a magical quality, and soon the value of the object outstrips and becomes disconnected from any functional utility it may have. Next comes the*